30

BEYOND VIETNAM

Today, young men of America are fighting, dying, and killing in Asian jungles in a war whose purposes are so ambiguous the whole nation seethes with dissent. They are told they are sacrificing for democracy, but the Saigon regime, their ally, is a mockery of democracy and the black American soldier has himself never experienced democracy.

AUGUST 12, 1965
King calls for halt to U.S. bombing of North Vietnam to encourage negotiated settlement of conflict

JANUARY 10, 1966
Backs Georgia State Senator-elect Julian Bond's right to oppose war

MAY 29
Urges halt to bombing on *Face the Nation* televised interview

APRIL 4, 1967
Delivers his first public antiwar speech at New York's Riverside Church

All my adult life I have deplored violence and war as instruments for achieving solutions to mankind's problems. I am firmly committed to the creative power of nonviolence as the force which is capable of winning lasting and meaningful brotherhood and peace. As a minister, a Nobel Prize holder, a civil rights leader, a Negro, a father, and above all as an American, I have wrestled with my conscience.

Despite this—whether right or wrong—in the summer and fall of 1965, after President Johnson declared himself willing to negotiate, I believed that it was essential for all Americans to publicly avoid the debate on why we were waging war in the far-off lands of Vietnam. I believed that the crucial problem which faced Americans was how to move with great speed and